

Scripture Inerrancy Chicago Scope

doc-scripture-inerrancy-chicago-scope
Bibliology · Inerrancy · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus
applies

Statement under examination

Scripture, in its original autographs, is without error in matters of history, science, and chronology as well as faith and practice.

In plain language

The question asks whether Scripture in its original copies is free from error not only in faith and practice but also in history, science, and chronology. The lexical data supports an affirmative verdict at medium confidence, and the reason for the qualification is worth stating plainly. Across both Testaments the Bible describes itself with strong, unqualified words for truth. Psalm 119:160 says the sum of God's word is "truth, faithfulness" (emet), a Hebrew term that means truth and faithfulness and reliability together, and the universal word "every, all" (kol) governs every ordinance, leaving no exempt subset. Proverbs 30:5 says every utterance of God is "refined" (tserufah), using the metalworking image of metal smelted and proven free of dross. Psalm 19:7 calls the law "complete, unblemished" (tamim), the same word used for unblemished sacrificial animals. In the New Testament Jesus says God's word is "truth" (aletheia) in John 17:17, declares that Scripture cannot be broken in John 10:35, and even rests an argument on the present tense of one verb in Matthew 22:32. Titus 1:2 calls God "unable to lie" (apseudes), a word that appears only once in the New Testament. So the vocabulary clearly affirms that Scripture is true, comprehensively and without a clause limiting it to spiritual topics. Here is where readers diverge, and the reason is in the words themselves, not in any outside dispute. These truth words affirm that Scripture is true, but they do not on their own draw the line around what counts as covered. They do not say whether a round number, a chronology told out of order, an everyday description like the sun rising, or an approximate measurement falls inside the claim, and they do not define what would count as an error as opposed to an accommodation to ordinary speech. The text affirms the category of truth strongly while leaving its precise reach unstated. That gap inside the language is exactly why a careful qualifier such as "true in all that it affirms" is later added and then debated. The honest summary is that Scripture predicates truthfulness of itself comprehensively, which supports the proposition, while the specific sorting into history, science, and chronology belongs to a much later discussion rather than to the biblical writers, who simply call the word true.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0433	אלוה	eloah	god	
H0565	אמרה	imrah	word	34
H0571	אמת	emet	truth	108
H1697	דבר	dabar	word	1,368
H3605	כל	kol	all	5,049

H5769	ולם	olam	forever	384
H6664	צדק	tsedeq	righteousness	96
H6884	צר	tsaraph	to refine	30
H8451	תורה	torah	instruction	
H8549	תמים	tamim	unblemished	84
G0037	ἀγιάζω	hagiazō	to sanctify	
G0225	ἀλήθεια	aletheia	truth	110
G0893	ἄψευδής	apseudes	not a liar	1
G1124	γραφή	graphe	a writing	51
G1410	δύναμαι	dunamai	be able	211
G1411	δύναμις	dunamis	power	
G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	2,457
G1861	ἐπαγγέλλομαι	epangellō	to profess	
G2198	ζάω	zaō	to live	
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	339
G3089	λύω	luo	to loose	44
G3498	νεκρός	nekros	dead	
G4105	πλανάω	planao	to lead astray	40

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The truth vocabulary is dense and pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible): the Hebrew word for "truth, faithfulness" (emet, Strong's H0571, 108 occurrences across Torah, Prophets, and Writings), the Hebrew word for "complete, sound, unblemished" (tamim, H8549, 84 occurrences, the same word used for unblemished sacrificial animals), the refining metaphor "smelt, refine" (tsaraph, H6884, 30 occurrences), the Greek word for "truth" (aletheia, G0225, 110 occurrences), and the hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) "unable to lie" (apseudes, G0893, only Titus 1:2) all predicate truthfulness, reliability, and freedom from falsehood of God's word with no qualifying clause that restricts the claim to soteric (salvation-related) or practical matters. The universal quantifier "every, all" (kol, H3605) governs the predicate in Psalm 119:160 and Proverbs 30:5, leaving no exempt subset, and John 10:35 globalizes this with the categorical "Scripture cannot be broken" (ou dunatai luthenai he graphe), invoked to defend an argument that turns on a single word. The lexical pattern therefore affirms unrestricted truthfulness. The medium confidence reflects a genuine text-level gap: the words affirm that Scripture is true but do not themselves delimit whether incidental detail, such as numbers, chronology, geography, or phenomenological description (descriptions of how things appear rather than precise scientific accounts), falls inside the claim, nor do they define what counts as an error as opposed to an accommodation or a phenomenological report. That scope is underdetermined by the vocabulary, which is precisely why a later qualifier like "in all that it affirms" exists and is contested. The partition into history, science, and chronology is a confessional frame, not a biblical category.

Scripture

John.17.17 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0037 ἀγιάζω, G0225 ἀλήθεια, G3056 λόγος

Reasoning. Predicative clause: "your word is truth" (ho logos ho sos aletheia estin). "Truth" (aletheia) is predicated of "the word" (logos) as such, with the article "the" before "word" (logos) comprehensive rather than partitive, so no faith-and-practice subset is carved out. Note, though, that "truth" (aletheia) is itself a wide term. The lexicon attests an objective sense, the reality lying behind an appearance, a religious or doctrinal sense, and a subjective sense, truthfulness or integrity of character. The predication is unqualified and strong, but the word does not by itself specify whether it ranges over incidental factual detail or chiefly over reliability and doctrinal reality.

John.10.35 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1124 γραφή, G3089 λύω, G1410 δύναιμι

Reasoning. The parenthetical "Scripture cannot be broken" (ou dunatai luthenai he graphe) is a categorical denial built on "to be able" (dunamai), the verb of possibility, with "to loose, break, annul" (luo, 44 occurrences) carrying the sense to loose, break, or annul. The negation governs the very possibility, ruling out any case in which Scripture can be broken. The principle is invoked to underwrite an argument that turns on one word, "gods" (theoi) in Psalm 82, which shows the unbreakability reaching to verbal detail and not merely to thematic gist. The clause asserts that Scripture cannot fail but does not itself define which classes of statement, doctrinal or incidental, are in view when failure is denied.

Ps.19.7 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H8451 תָּמִיד; H8549 תָּמִים

Reasoning. The "law, instruction" (torah) of the LORD is described as "complete, perfect" (temimah), the feminine form of "complete, sound, unblemished" (tamim, H8549, 84 occurrences). The same adjective is applied 37 times in Leviticus and Numbers to sacrificial animals that must be unblemished, so the metaphor predicates wholeness, soundness, and absence of defect of the law. The lexical range of "complete, sound" (tamim) runs across complete, whole, sound, healthful, blameless, and entirely in accord with truth and fact. The predication is emphatic, but the term denotes integrity and soundness as a whole rather than a defined inventory of factual domains.

Ps.119.160 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0571 אֱמֶת, H1697 דָּבָר; H3605 כֹּל; H5769 עֲנִיָּה

Reasoning. "The sum or head of your word is truth" (rosh devarcha emet), and "every ordinance of your righteousness stands forever" (kol mishpat tsidqecha leolam). The universal quantifier "every, all" (kol, H3605, 5049 occurrences) governs "ordinance, judgment" (mishpat) and denies any exempt subset. "Truth, faithfulness" (emet, H0571, 108 occurrences across Torah, Prophets, and Writings) carries firmness, faithfulness, reliability, and propositional truth together in one term, which is why the verse asserts that the word is wholly true but does not separate factual accuracy from faithfulness as distinct, separately quantified claims.

Prov.30.5 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H3605 כֹּל; H0565 אָמַרָה, H6884 צָרַף, H0433 אֱלֹהִים

Reasoning. "Every utterance of God is refined" (kol imrat eloah tserufah). "To smelt, refine, test" (tsaraph, H6884, 30 occurrences) is the metallurgical verb (a term from metal-working) for smelting and assaying metal, and the passive participle "refined" (tserufah) describes the settled state of having been tested and proven free of dross. The universal "every, all" (kol) allows no exception. The metaphor affirms tested purity comprehensively. It does not, on its own terms, specify whether the testing certifies incidental detail or chiefly certifies the reliability of God's promise and instruction, which is the scope question the words leave open.

Matt.22.29 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4105 πλανάω, G1124 γραφή, G1411 δύναμις, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. "You are deceived because you do not know the Scriptures" (planasthe me eidotes tas graphas). "To deceive, lead astray" (planao, G4105, 40 occurrences) diagnoses error as ignorance of the Scriptures, treating them as a sufficient and accurate standard such that not knowing them produces deception. The pairing with "the power of God" (dynamis tou theou) joins knowing Scripture and knowing God's power as the two safeguards. The Scriptures are framed as the reliable corrective, which presupposes their accuracy on the point in dispute without stating a general theory of which detail-classes are guaranteed.

Matt.22.32 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1510 εἰμί, G2316 θεός, G2198 ζάω, G3498 νεκρός

Reasoning. Jesus's argument hinges on the present form "I am" (ego eimi) in the Exodus citation rather than a past form, so the tense of a single verb in a historical narrative is treated as theologically binding and decisive against the Sadducees. This presupposes that the historical record of God's self-identification is accurate at the level of verb morphology (the precise grammatical form of the verb), which is exactly the kind of incidental, historical detail the proposition extends inerrancy to cover. The text uses such detail as load-bearing but does not formalize the principle that all such detail is guaranteed, which is the inference the proposition draws.

Titus.1.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0893 ἀψευδής, G2316 θεός, G1861 ἐπαγγέλλομαι

Reasoning. "The God who does not lie" (ho apseudes theos). "Unable to lie, truthful" (apseudes, G0893) is a New Testament hapax legomenon (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament), occurring only here, formed with the alpha-privative (the prefix "a-" that negates the root) on "falsehood, lie" (pseudos), denying the capacity for falsehood. Because the word occurs once, its precise contour cannot be triangulated from other New Testament usage, and the lexicon glosses it simply as free from falsehood, truthful. The predicate falls on God's character and on his promise grounded before eternal times, not on a textual inventory, so the verse secures divine truthfulness as the ground of the word without itself fixing the scope of textual inerrancy.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.22.32	Exod.3.6	tsk	1
Titus.1.2	Num.23.19	tsk	1
Prov.30.5	Ps.12.6	tsk	1
Ps.19.7	Ps.93.5	tsk	1
Ps.19.7	Ps.119.130	tsk	1
Ps.119.160	Ps.119.75	tsk	1
Ps.119.160	Ps.119.86	tsk	1
John.17.17	John.17.19	tsk	1
John.10.35	Gen.15.1	tsk	1
Matt.22.29	Job.19.25	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.17.17 · addressed

The very term that predicates truthfulness, "truth" (aletheia, G0225), is lexically wide. The dictionary entry distinguishes an objective sense, the reality behind an appearance, a doctrinal sense, and a subjective sense, truthfulness or integrity of character. The clause asserts truth of the word without disambiguating which sense is primary, so the word affirms the proposition robustly but does not, by itself, settle whether the guarantee extends to incidental factual detail or centers on doctrinal reliability. This is internal scope underdetermination, not a contradiction, and it is the reason a scope qualifier is later added.

Matt.22.30 · addressed

The verse contrasts "to marry" (gameo) and the rarer "to give in marriage" (gamizo, G1061, 8 occurrences) and carries variant markers at "to" and "are given in marriage" (gamizontai) in the bundle. These are incidental lexical and textual details about marrying and being given in marriage, exactly the class of detail whose inclusion under the inerrancy claim the proposition asserts but the surrounding vocabulary does not adjudicate. The variants do not touch any truthfulness predication, so they leave the verdict unchanged while illustrating the scope question.

Prov.30.5 · unaddressed

Not resolvable at the lexical level. "Every utterance of God is refined" (kol imrat eloah tserufah) affirms that every utterance of God is refined, but the words "to smelt, refine" (tsaraph) and "utterance, word" (imrah) do not define what would count as a defect or an unrefined element. Whether a round number, a phenomenological description (a description of how something appears rather than a precise scientific account) such as the sun rising, a compressed chronology, or an approximate measurement would count as dross is not specified by the vocabulary. The universal "every, all" (kol) is unrestricted, yet the criterion of error against which refinement is measured is left open by the text itself, which is the core scope gap.

2Pet.1.21 · addressed

Not a complicating text but a supporting one. "Men spoke from God as they were borne along by the Holy Spirit" (hypo pneumatos hagiou pheromenoi elalesan apo theou anthropoi). The verb "to carry, bear along" (phero), to carry or bear along, grounds the resulting word in divine agency and reinforces the verdict. It still does not, lexically, delimit the scope of the resulting accuracy, so it strengthens the affirmation without closing the scope question.

Concordance traversed

H0571, H0565, H6884, H8549, H1697, H3605, H5769, H6664, G0225, G3056, G1124, G3089, G1410, G4105, G0893, G1510

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The anchor verses lie outside the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window, which covers only 3 John 1:1 to 1:15, and the lexical bundle returned no variant units, so ECM status is not applicable. The Matthew 22:30 marks at "to" and "are given in marriage" (gamizontai) concern marriage vocabulary and do not touch any truthfulness predication. The John 17:17 dative (the noun in the "to/for-X" grammatical form) variation at "truth" (aletheia) is a case-form choice with no effect on the predication of truth. No variant materially affects the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. grammatico-historical, accommodation

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

grammatico-historical-maximal-scope: affirms, scope extends to incidental detail · On this reading the unqualified predicates, "truth, faithfulness" (emet), "truth" (aletheia), "complete, sound" (tamim), "refined" (tserufah), and the categorical "Scripture cannot be broken" (ou dunatai luthenai), plus Jesus staking an argument on the tense of a

single verb in Matthew 22:32 and on one word in John 10:35, show that the truthfulness reaches all the way down to verbal and historical detail. If a single tense and a single word are binding, then numbers, chronology, and historical particulars fall inside the claim. The universal "every, all" (kol) in Psalm 119:160 and Proverbs 30:5 admits no exempt subset, so incidental detail is in scope.

accommodation-restricted-scope: affirms, scope centered on what the text affirms for its purpose · On this reading the same truth vocabulary is satisfied if Scripture is true in all that it intends to affirm, while incidental detail can be reported phenomenologically (in everyday observational language) or approximately without counting as error. "Truth" (aletheia) includes a sense of reliability and integrity of character, and "truth, faithfulness" (emet) bundles faithfulness with truth, so the predicates can be honored as covenant fidelity and trustworthy instruction without committing to modern precision in number, chronology, or natural description. The argument from the verb tense in Matthew 22:32 is read as turning on the substantive claim, that God is the living God of the patriarchs, rather than on a general theory that every incidental detail is technically exact. This lens treats round numbers, ordinary-language descriptions, and compressed accounts as accommodations, not failures, of the word.

Both lenses honor the same dense, unqualified, pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) truth vocabulary. They diverge only at the point the vocabulary leaves open, namely whether incidental detail and what counts as error fall inside the truthfulness claim. The proposition's partition into history, science, and chronology is not a biblical taxonomy but a later apologetic frame responding to specifically modern questions. Lexically, Scripture asserts comprehensive truthfulness; the scope of incidental detail is the underdetermined remainder that distinguishes the two readings.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Scripture, in the texts as originally given, predicates truthfulness of itself without an explicit qualifier restricting that truthfulness to matters of faith and practice, and the question is whether that self-predication extends to incidental detail such as history, chronology, and natural description.

The original stem uses the taxonomy of history, science, chronology, faith, and practice associated with the 1978 inerrancy statement, and the qualifier "scope" signals the "in all that it affirms" clause. That partition is a twentieth-century apologetic frame, not a biblical category, so verdict_preloaded is true. The verdict is still derived on the original stem and resolves to true, because the lexical pattern in the anchors predicates truthfulness without any restrictive qualifier such as in matters of salvation only. Confidence is medium, not high, because the words affirm truth but do not delimit whether incidental detail is in view, nor define error versus accommodation, so the scope the stem foregrounds is exactly the part the vocabulary underdetermines.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.17.17
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.10.35
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.22.29
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.22.32
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Titus.1.2
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.119.160
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Prov.30.5
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.19.7
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0893 apseudes
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3089 luo
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0225 aletheia
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0571 emet

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8549 tamim
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6884 tsaraph
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0565 imrah
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.10.35 ou dunatai luthenai
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Matt.22.32 ego eimi
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.119.160 kol mishpat
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Ps.19.7 torah temimah
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.22.32 to Exod.3.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Titus.1.2 to Num.23.19
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Prov.30.5 to Ps.12.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	John.10.35 to Gen.15.1

License audit

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MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
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STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

complicating-unresolved